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Affective injustice

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ABSTRACT

Oppression, marginalization, and other forms of disadvantage often come with emotional burdens, such as feelings of insecurity or stress. At the same time, some features of oppression are emotional in nature—for example, the dismissal of anger coming from victims of racial or gender injustice. The concept of affective injustice aims to capture the distinctively emotional wrongs that contribute to, or themselves constitute, unfair disadvantage. This article offers a critical overview of the existing literature on affective injustice, understood as the unjust interference with people's affective lives.

KEYWORDS

affective justice, emotion, well-being, equality, aptness

1. Introduction

Emotions, or more generally, people's affective lives, have long been important matters in the study of social, moral, and political normativity. For example, care ethicists and capability theorists give a central role to love and personal relationships, while philosophers of race and gender have reclaimed the epistemic and political power of disruptive emotions. The emergent

debate on *affective injustice* allows for a systematised and focused analysis of forms of injustice that are distinctively emotional in nature, while cutting across existing discussions on emotion and normativity. In the same way epistemic injustice highlights wrongs related to doxastic attitudes and experience, affective injustice highlights wrongs related to emotional attitudes and experience.¹ It seems wrong, for example, to demand a Black man that he calms down when he is addressed with a racial slur. Policies that induce fear on women or migrants also seem wrongful, and so does the social imposition of hegemonic mourning practices on religious minorities. Individuals and groups in those circumstances may be, of course, victims of several harms, wrongs and injustices, and the situations themselves may be unjust for different reasons. The concept of affective injustice captures the distinctively emotional wrongs that are involved in these contexts, as well as explaining how these wrongs are not merely psychological, but social and structural wrongs—which ought to be avoided or corrected in the pursuit of a just society.

2. Affective injustice: an overview of the debate

The concept of affective injustice was first postulated by Amia Srinivasan (2018) and Shiloh Whitney (2018), who independently identified two sets of (related, but distinct) wrongs with regards to emotional expression, often suffered by people who are already victims of injustice.

Srinivasan argued that when victims of injustice experience anger about their subordination, they face a normative conflict between prudence and aptness. While expressing their anger can be prudentially counterproductive for them—since people in positions of power might be less keen to listen, for example—their anger is fitting or apt, meaning that it accurately represents features of the world—such as the oppression they experience as members of a subordinated group.² Having to choose between representing the world correctly and following prudential reasons constitutes an internal normative conflict for these people. For Srinivasan (2018, 127; 133), this double-bind is an “insidious choice” between “two competing and significant goods that often feel incomparable”, and is thus an unrecognised form of injustice—*affective injustice*.

Whitney expanded the understanding of emotional function, arguing that emotions are not merely a way to apprehend the world, but a means to move others—where being moved is a way of making one’s affective investments sensible to an interlocutor.³ Inspired by Iris Marion Young’s (1990) faces of oppression, Whitney identified three forms of affective injustice. For

Whitney, not giving uptake to someone's emotions—refusing to being moved by them—constitutes affective marginalisation, since it makes that person's affective experience not count—it does not make a difference socially. At the same time, oppressed people are forced to process the emotions of dominant groups, thus becoming affectively exploited. Focusing on the phenomenological dimension of these two forms of affective injustice, Whitney (2018, 497) claimed that these often coalesce into affective violence. This third form of injustice results from being forced to process one's own affect that is not given uptake, as well as the imposed affects of others—these become “toxic” in one's body, impairing one's affective capacities.

Two further forms of affective injustice were then proposed by Alfred Archer and Benjamin Matheson (2023), concentrating on how groups can inflict affective injustice. First, they introduced the notion of affective rights or ‘rights to feel’, which may be minimally understood as an entitlement to affective autonomy: the capacity to determine one's emotional responses without undue pressure from others to feel or express certain emotions. Affective rights can be violated by a society's imposition of admiration of the military, colonial history, or the monarchy, for example.⁴ Second, they coined the term ‘emotional imperialism’ to refer to a form of group domination that involves the imposition of (elements of) a dominator's emotional regime on the dominated—where emotional regimes are defined as the set of norms that shapes the emotional lives of the members of that society and grounds political stability. These norms do not only determine what emotions are fitting or apt, but also “how to prioritize fitting emotions when they conflict, how to interpret our and others' emotions, how we should regulate our emotions, and what practices express particular emotions” (Archer and Matheson 2023, 9).⁵

Moving beyond the identification of specific forms of affective injustice, Francisco Gallegos (2022) put forward an overarching account that defined the conditions for something to count as an affective injustice. For Gallegos, affective injustice is the morally objectionable deprivation of affective goods that individuals or groups are entitled to. Specifically, people are entitled to two fundamental affective goods that are non-instrumental for the attainment of other goods and non-reducible (to other goods or to each other). The first fundamental affective good is subjective well-being, understood as emotional health. The second is emotional aptness, which is the practice of apprehending the world through fitting emotions. Gallegos acknowledges that these fundamental goods cannot be allocated directly, and claims that they can be attained instead through the provision of subsidiary affective goods: affective resources (such as sleep

and self-care), opportunities (such as education to hone one's emotional responses), freedoms (such as freedom from poverty-induced stress) and recognition (like one's emotions receiving uptake by others).

These four accounts, which we can call the *core views* of affective injustice, have since been refined by the authors themselves (Archer and Matheson 2023; Whitney 2023) and (re-)developed by others (Krueger 2023; Pismenny et al. 2024; Slaby 2023; Stockdale 2023). The debate has steadily grown through research with narrower aims, such as discussing specific forms of affective injustice, identifying affective injustice in a variety of practical domains, and exploring the concept from continental and non-Western traditions. Thus, on forms of affective injustice there have been contributions on emotional regulation (Archer and Mills 2019; Villa 2024), affective dismissal (Bell 2023), affective stereotyping (Cherry 2023), tone policing (MacLachlan 2023), double binds (Silva et. Al 2026), and affective gaslighting (Whitney 2023, Whitney 2025; also discussed in Cherry 2023 and Zembylas 2024a). On particular emotional phenomena, philosophers have looked at the connection between affective injustice and fear (Archer and Mills 2025, Puddifoot 2025), shame (Gallegos 2023), self-respect (Edlich 2026), anger (Hildebrand and Jackson 2025), hope (Li 2023), fatigue (Rathe 2025), love and care (Tessman 2023), the 'unfelt' (Slaby 2023, Zembylas 2026a), and existential or background feelings (Vespermann and Tirkonnen 2024). In applied settings, affective injustice has been explored with regards to racist statues (Archer 2024), healthcare (Bogaert 2025, Floris et al. 2026, Pismenny 2025), artificial intelligence (Dale and Gubka 2025; Goffin and Archer 2025; Wong 2025), disabled and trans identities (Eickers 2024), mental health (Isern-Mas and Almagro 2025; Lavallee and Gagné-Julien 2024), parasocial relationships (Isern-Mas et al. 2025), hostile architecture (Krueger 2023), autism (Krueger 2023, Goffin 2026), gentrification and migration (Lopez-Cantero 2025), family abuse (Mills 2019), design (Osler et al. 2025), meritocracy and income inequality (Thomas et al. 2025), asexuality (Walter and aus dem Bruch 2026), online contexts (Wildman et al. 2022), climate vulnerability (Zembylas 2026b), and education (Zembylas 2024a; 2024b; 2024c; 2025b). Finally, the concept has been explored from a Schelerian approach (Ambrosino 2025) and from the perspective of African moral theory (Carman 2023; 2024).

These contributions have progressively built on the core views. They have also drawn connections with relevant philosophical debates, such as epistemic injustice, phenomenology, and cognition, although some important links are yet to be developed.

3. Definition and categories of affective injustice

The first overarching definition of affective injustice was put forward by Alfred Archer and Georgina Mills (2019). Drawing a parallel with the definition of epistemic injustice (injustice faced by people in their capacity as knowers), they defined affective injustice as injustice faced by people in their capacity as affective beings (Archer and Mills 2019, 75). Most participants in the debate use this definition as a starting point.⁶ A more informative definition has been advanced by Joel Krueger (2023, 85), who states that affective injustice “involves limitations on our ability to experience, express, regulate, interpret, and share our emotions and other feelings”. However, it should be noted that not all limitations to this ability are unjust and there might be other relevant affective practices not mentioned in the definition. It is then best to use a more generic term than ‘deprivation’ or ‘limitation’, such as ‘interference’. Also, some affective injustices do not involve one’s own emotions, but those of others—for example, being the object of racist fear (Archer and Mills 2025, Pismenny et al. 2024). The strengths of the existing definitions can be incorporated into a definition that is sufficiently general and informative in order to avoid those issues (where the parenthesis may be included or omitted for a complete or short-handed definition):

Affective injustice is the unjust interference with people’s affective lives, with regard to their own affective practices or through those of others (such as the experience, expression, regulation, interpretation, and sharing of emotions and other affective phenomena).

Two ways of categorizing affective injustice emerge from the current literature. The first one is according to the specific affective phenomenon that is at stake. Daniel Vespermann and Sanna Tirkonnen (2024) propose the term ‘(affective) existential injustice’ to refer to wrongs with regards to existential or background feelings. These are understood as non-intentional felt orientations towards reality, such as anxiety, guilt or feelings of not belonging.⁷ Krueger’s (2023) ‘ecological injustice’ picks up on an affective phenomenon that is not psychological or interpersonal, but environmental: affordances. Krueger argues that affective injustice can be

built into the environment through the presence or absence of affordances—possibilities for action and (emotional) experience as enabled by things, spaces, and other people.⁸

A second route in the existing discussions categorises instances of affective injustice according to the nature of the affective wrong at hand. Emotional imperialism, for example, is a form of affective domination (Archer and Matheson 2023). We can also talk of ‘uptake injustice’ as a specific type of wrong that defines a specific kind of affective injustice—the discrediting of a person’s emotion due to a prejudiced uptake economy (Whitney 2023).⁹ Other taxonomy proposals have differentiated between having one’s emotions dismissed, the weaponization of emotions to unfairly disadvantage others, and being the target of inapt emotions (Archer and Mills 2025). Arina Pismenny et al. (2024) further narrow down these three kinds of affective injustice to seven more specific ones, each of them with several sub-categories.

As the debate currently stands, however, it makes sense to classify all instances of affective injustice according to the two broad and overarching categories postulated by Gallegos: interferences with emotional aptness and interferences with subjective well-being. Given that the existing categorisations (existential injustice, ecological injustice, emotional imperialism, uptake injustice, and others) are not mutually exclusive, concrete actions and situations can be further labelled depending on how much specification is needed about the affective phenomenon or the affective wrong at hand.

Discussions surrounding affective injustice—its usefulness, criticisms, and potential responses—have mostly focused on emotional aptness, while subjective well-being has been a more secondary concern. This makes sense, given that emotional aptness is more distinctively affective, while subjective well-being is a more general consideration that encompasses non-affective components as well. For that reason, the next two sections draw primarily from existing discussions regarding emotional aptness—subjective well-being is one of the main lines of future research in affective injustice, which are discussed in the last section.

4. Purpose and criticisms

As mentioned earlier, the notion of affective injustice is a direct inheritor of earlier feminist and decolonial views on the epistemic and political role of anger and disruptive emotions (Fanon 1963/2004; Frye 1983; Jaggar 1989; Lorde 1984; Lugones 2003; Narayan 1988). This is explicitly acknowledged by most contributors to the debate, who also recognise and draw from Iris Marion

Young's (1990) pioneering work on non-material and structural forms and conditions of injustice. In light of this existing literature, what is then the purpose of the notion of affective injustice?

First, the notion of affective injustice lends itself to a greater variety of emotional experiences: while much of the earlier literature on political emotions was centred around disruptive ones with a particular emphasis on anger (Cherry 2021), we have seen in section 1 that discussants of affective injustice are looking into many other dimensions of affective lives, including—but not limited to—a wider range of emotions.

Second, by cutting across debates on justice, emotion, race, and gender, the notion of affective injustice affords a specific focus on emotional phenomena, while remaining sufficiently general to apply to a range of lived experiences (which may be marked by injustice due to belonging to a marginalised group, injustice on grounds other than group belonging, or, according to some authors, even independently of personal experiences of injustice).

Third, the debate has expanded the shared grounds between views of justice and novel frameworks in phenomenology, philosophy of cognition, and philosophy of mind, such as situated affectivity and environmental scaffolding.¹⁰ In turn, this can act as support for the consolidation of 'political philosophy of mind' (Maiese & Hanna 2019, Tzima & Slaby 2024), a subfield that examines how mental states, capacities, and affective experiences intersect with social and political structures, and how power, norms, and institutions shape, recognise, or harm minds.

Now, even if it is a useful concept, the notion of affective injustice faces important criticisms. One commonly raised objection is that the appeal to 'injustice' may be setting the bar too high when discussing affective lives (Bell 2023, Plunkett 2021). This first line of criticism focuses on the grounds of affective injustice, and already available responses are explained next. Another source of scepticism is that people do not plausibly have a universal entitlement to have all their emotional responses recognised as apt, or are owed a life that is completely free of negative emotions. This second objection is focused on the nature and conditions for affective justice, which is among the main questions for future research that are presented in the last section.

5. The grounds of affective injustice

The question of the grounds of affective injustice is the question of what makes an interference with someone's affective lives unjust. Some interferences with affective lives, both in terms of emotional aptness and subjective well-being, are justified, or benign, even when they deprive the person of fundamental affective goods—in which case they seem to be *prima facie* not unjust. For example, a child might rightfully be deprived of joy when banned from eating sweets before dinner. Concealing hurtful information from a friend can be better for them than revealing it so that they can have emotionally apt responses. Uncontroversially, it seems that a misogynist's anger due to 'reverse discrimination' should not be given any uptake.

To understand why some interferences with affective lives are unjust and others are not, first it should be noted that discussants of affective injustice do not universally endorse a clear and explicit distinction between affective harms, affective wrongs, and affective injustices.¹¹ For that reason, criticisms of specific views and of the notion of affective injustice as a whole sometimes arise on the basis of unacknowledged meta-ethical and normative disagreements. This is compounded by the fact that discussions on affective injustice can have three distinct loci (first-personal, second-personal, and structural) and authors sometimes highlight one or the other—particularly when discussing emotional aptness.

Interferences with emotional aptness (let it be through deprivation, imposition, manipulation, or other forms) can entail a first-personal wrong because affective processes and experiences—specially emotions—are a crucial component people's ability to value. As Macalester Bell (2023) explains, to value something is to become vulnerable to emotions regarding that thing and to experience emotions as fitting responses to what is valued.¹² Emotions are then crucial for people's understanding the world, for their moral agency, and for their sense of self. Crucially, affective experiences reveal what matters subjectively to someone, so they express what is personally important to them (Archer and Mills 2025; Whitney 2023); through affective experiences people identify themselves with what they value (Bell 2023). Further, the interference with emotional aptness disrupts people's ability to participate in the creation of socially shared meanings about shared affective practices. The nature of these first-personal wrongs has been explained in terms of disrespect (Bell 2023, 245), disruption of affective autonomy (Archer and Matheson 2023; Bell 2023), or disruption of moral agency (Ambrosino 2025; Whitney 2023).

From a second-personal perspective, authors have discussed how wrongdoers can directly inflict the aforementioned first-personal wrongs by refusing to give uptake to their emotions (Whitney 2018, 2023), dismissing them (Bell 2023), pathologizing them (Lavallee and Gagné-Julien 2024; Pismenny et al. 2024; Whitney 2023) or policing them (MacLachlan 2023; Pismenny et al. 2024). The second-personal perspective shows why people who deprive others of emotional aptness may be considered wrongdoers: because they fail to respect the person (Bell 2023) or to take them seriously as someone whose affective concerns matter, and who themselves matter (Archer and Mills 2025; Whitney 2023).

When putting the focus on specific and delimited interactions between individuals, however, it should be taken into account that these interactions, and the motivations of the people involved, are shaped by affective practices, norms, and relationships at the structural level. Sometimes, discussions on structural wrongs refer to identifiable wrongdoers with the intent to deprive people of emotional aptness and the institutional power to do so, like in the cases of design of hostile architecture (Krueger 2023) or the direct exercise of imperial ruling (Archer and Matheson 2023). But often, the deprivation of emotional aptness happens without such specific intent, or without identifiable wrongdoers, through the habitual enactment of shared affective practices, norms, and relationships that themselves (re)produce existing injustice (Archer and Matheson 2023; Stockdale 2023; Whitney 2023, Slaby 2023).

Acknowledging the existence of meta-ethical and normative disagreements, and differentiating between the three loci of injustice, are crucial steps to understand two different positions with regard to the grounds of affective injustice. First, discussants such as Bell (2023, 256) look at affective injustice (in her case, the specific form of affective dismissal) mostly in terms of a second-personal wrong, and understand wrongdoing in terms of a right violation. Because it seems dubious that people have a right to have their emotions always recognised or a life free of negative emotions, and because the locus of affective injustice is second-personal according to her, Bell is sceptical of the use of the term ‘injustice’, which she argues should be reserved to wrongs that hurt society as a whole. Bell’s view can then accommodate interferences with affective lives are not unjust, like the examples at the beginning of this section, but because of her meta-ethical and normative commitments and her focus on the second-personal level, the view triggers scepticism about the very notion of affective injustice.

The second approach sees affective injustice as grounded on general structural injustice. This is the approach adopted by the core views, according to which affective injustice is a constitutive element of other social injustices such as racism, sexism, or imperialism. From this approach, interference with affective lives is unjust when it (re)produces existing forms of injustice (Whitney 2023; Slaby 2023), where injustice has been generally understood as unfair disadvantage or unjust treatment (i.e. domination or exploitation) brought about at the structural level. This approach preserves the notion of affective injustice while in principle allowing to differentiate between unjust and not unjust interferences with affective lives: these are only unjust if they constitute or reinforce other forms of injustice, so depriving the child of joy, or ignoring the anger of a misogynist, are not instances of affective injustice.

When it comes to identifying who¹³ can be a victim of affective injustice, the structural approach can be interpreted in two further ways. Most authors endorse—explicitly or implicitly—the view that victims of affective injustice are already victims of other injustices: they are poor, racialised, disabled, or colonised, for example, and the unjust interference with their affective lives compounds on and partially constitutes those existing injustices. In other words, affective injustice is “parasitic” on other forms of injustice, to use Srinivasan’s (2018, 135) phrase. However, Katie Stockdale (2023) believes that since affective injustice is grounded at the structural level, individuals from dominant groups can also suffer from affective injustice. In fact, some second-personal wrongdoing committed by individuals from dominant groups can be explained by structurally unjust affective practices, norms and relationships (even if it does not morally justify it). For example, the socialisation of men to be overconfident, which affirms their dominant position in social hierarchy, may explain their dismissal of women’s emotions (Pismenny et al. 2024, 155). This not only wrongs women, who are directly deprived of emotional aptness in this sort of interaction: it also wrongs men, since their own ability to experience, understand and give uptake to emotions is skewed by unjust shared affective practices, relationships, and norms.

Here, it may be useful to articulate a normative distinction more explicitly than has been done in the debate so far. Namely, it is possible to acknowledge that the (re)production of injustice in the affective domain will sometimes be detrimental (i.e., harmful or even wrongful) to members of dominant groups, without this entailing that these individuals are themselves victims of affective injustice. These individuals might suffer harms and/or wrongs that are affective in

nature, but these are not enabled by social conditions that make *them* victims of injustice. This understanding also allows for the accommodation of intersectional concerns, so that when affective injustice is instantiated in interactions between people who are both disadvantaged, they can both be considered victims of affective injustice, but on different grounds.¹⁴

6. Future directions

There are three important matters that have come up in the debate, but that need further research in order to appropriately ground the notion of affective injustice: the internal contradiction between apt and inapt emotions, the role of subjective well-being, and the conditions for affective justice.

6.1. *The role of inapt emotions*

Lisa Tessman (2023) argues that the excessive focus on emotional aptness overlooks that inapt emotions also have a role in affective lives. Specifically, she argues that the uptake of inapt emotions is a requirement of unconditional love, given that despite not being appropriately grounded in reality, these emotions do reveal what matters to the loved person. This worry may be addressed by adopting a pluralist stance: different situations can admit for different standards of aptness (Gallegos 2022, 198, n. 14). Still, inapt emotions do give rise to an important tension for proponents of affective injustice, as highlighted by Archer and Mills (2025). It could be argued in order to take people seriously, their inapt emotions should also be given uptake. Further, only by receiving uptake to their inapt emotions from others can people eventually learn to have more apt emotional responses. However, recall that being the target of inapt emotions can also constitute an affective injustice. If this is the case, how should unjust inapt emotions be assessed in terms of justice? The question is more pressing when intersectional concerns come into discussion—for example, when racialised people are prejudiced about people belonging to other racial groups, or when religious minorities advocate for the criminalisation of queerness. This tension, which is yet to be resolved, is not merely a matter of setting thresholds, since putting into question the role of emotional aptness could have significant consequences for the current understanding of grounds of affective injustice—which as it has been discussed, is primarily analysed in terms of interferences with emotional aptness.¹⁵

6.2. *Subjective well-being*

Besides Gallegos, only a handful of contributors have discussed injustices related to interferences with subjective well-being. This is perhaps because emotional aptness is a distinctively affective good that had not been systematised as a matter of justice, while there are already well-established discussions that capture the importance of subjective well-being for justice—as Gallegos (2022, 194) himself acknowledges. Care ethics (Gilligan 1982; Tronto 1993) and the capability approach (Nussbaum 2011; Sen 1999) are the most notable examples, but others have also highlighted the importance of affective lives for justice (e.g. Honneth 2004; Walzer 1983).

There is also a substantial body of work on ‘personal relationship goods’ (Gheaus 2022) among political philosophers and theorists. Personal relationship goods are non-material goods—such as love, affection, attachment, or loyalty—accrued in relationships with others—including friends, lovers, family, or neighbours (Gheaus 2022). These debates are still to be explored in connection with affective injustice, but there is an important matter to discern here: whether the deprivation of affective goods can be reduced to the deprivation of personal relationship goods. Tentatively, the notion of affective goods seems to cast a wider net than personal relationship goods. Personal relationships and social interaction do not account for all components of a person’s affective life that contribute to or disrupt subjective well-being, and are then relevant for justice (such as fear of unemployment, or lack of sleep due to unreliable public transport and long commutes). In turn, the debate of affective injustice has all but abandoned the possibility of there being affective rights (see n. 4), while there is a rich discussion on entitlements to personal relationship goods (Brownlee 2020; Brownlee et al. 2022; Collins and Shields 2025). Hence, it initially seems that the debates could potentially complement each other—not only with regards to injustices connected with subjective well-being, but also on what exactly would be the conditions of affective justice in general.¹⁶

6.3. *Affective justice*

As it has been explained, numerous contributors have addressed what makes interferences with affective lives unjust. However, there are counted mentions of *affective justice* or the paths to achieve it. This is an important question, in order to avoid the criticism that affective justice would require that all emotional responses of victims of injustice are recognised as apt, or that they (or even *everyone*) are owed a life that is completely free of negative emotions.

The most substantial discussion on affective justice is by Archer and Matheson (2023), who reject the view that the provision of emotional aptness and subjective well-being are enough to achieve affective justice. These affective goods, they argue, may be provided within structurally unjust societies—such as the imposition of emotional regimes characteristic of colonialism. Since affective justice should pre-empt dominating social hierarchies, it should take the form of *relational equality*: “One community of people should not be in a hierarchically superior position to impose their norms for emotional fittingness, prioritization, regulation, or practices on others in a way that advances the interests of the dominant” (Archer and Matheson 2023, 22). They then situate their view in opposition to Gallegos’s distributive approach, according to which affective justice demands a fair distribution of affective goods.¹⁷

Gallegos (2022, 196) says that affective justice is not an entitlement to happiness or emotional aptness, but to its pursuit—a matter of positive entitlements to the conditions required for either. However, the possibility of distributing affective goods themselves has received backing from Pismenny et al. (2024), while Pilar Lopez-Cantero (2025) argues that some policy decisions may have affective by-products in the shape of affective burdens, which can be distributed unequally—and thus unjustly—in an indirect manner.

Again, political philosophers and theorists have already made important contributions with regard to both the direct and the indirect (re-)distribution of goods that may be considered affective, such as friendship or care (Cordelli 2015a, 2015b; Gheaus 2009, 2018). Interacting with these debates will be crucial to determine the viability of distributive affective justice. From there on, it may be argued that affective justice is *either* a matter of equal relations *or* equal distribution, or it might be possible to put forward a pluralist view that prioritises both.¹⁸

5. Conclusion

The debate on affective injustice is grounded on the view that emotions and other affective phenomena are not merely private states, and instead play a substantial role in social and political life. The views discussed in this article do not aim at labelling any instance of emotional discomfort or disagreement as unjust, but at revealing how affective norms, practices and relationships can sustain or challenge structures of injustice, and how unjust interference with people’s affective lives constitutes a distinct form of wrongdoing that is worth studying. At the same time, there are important conceptual questions to address, and new contexts of

application to explore. It is important that future discussions do not subsume the latter to the former aim, and focus on strengthening the conceptual foundations of the notion of affective injustice. This will be crucial to establish the framework not only within academic settings, but also as a useful tool to identify, denounce, and resist instances of injustice that happen both at the institutional level and in everyday interactions.

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Endnotes

¹ In this paper I use the adjectives 'affective' and 'emotional' interchangeably. However, people's affective lives are constituted by a variety of affective phenomena, not limited to emotions—such as bodily feelings, moods, dispositions, and existential or background feelings (e.g. Fuchs 2013).

² This understanding of aptness is almost universally endorsed among discussants. One exception is Gallegos, who gives a teleological explanation for the value of emotional aptness stemming from his wider philosophy of emotion (Gallegos 2019). His view, however, need not be endorsed to understand the role of emotions in valuing and their relevance for justice.

³ Whitney (2018, 493) initially emphasized the notion of 'affective force', which has been criticized for assuming a mechanistic view of (affective) agency (Bell 2023, 259). Subsequently, Whitney (2023, 38) clarified what 'being moved' means, mitigating the physicality of the metaphor—this is the definition I use.

⁴ See Bell (2023, 251) for a similar view of affective autonomy, and Wenar (2003, 2015) for an earlier discussion on affective rights. Archer and Matheson (2023, 21-23) later proposed that affective autonomy should be considered a fundamental affective good within a deprivation-based approach of affective injustice, leaving aside the notion of affective rights. In any case, they did not endorse such approach, favouring a relational egalitarian view of affective injustice instead of the distributive view they attribute to Gallegos.

⁵ Their initial definition of emotional imperialism referred to the imposition of “emotional norms and standards” (Archer and Matheson 2022, 771), adapting Iris Marion Young’s (1990) concept of cultural imperialism to the affective domain. They later completed it by including William Reddy’s (2001) notion of emotional regime—this is the definition I use. See also Whitney’s (2023) discussion of the related concept of affective economies, which she adapts from Sara Ahmed (2004).

⁶ See Stockdale (2023, 115) and Pismenny et al. (2024, 154) for exceptions.

⁷ See also Rathe (2025) on fatigue.

⁸ Another possible category is ‘emotional injustice’. Pismenny et al. (2024, 152) propose a re-naming of affective injustice as ‘emotional injustice’ because they take ‘affect’ to refer only to valence of experience. Although this meaning does prevail in some academic circles, ‘affect’ is often used as a wider cross-category term in philosophy and other disciplines. Importantly, given that emotion is just one of the many constituents of affective lives, their attempt does not capture the explanandum. Being a victim of sexism, for example, may not only make a person angry at a given time (an emotion), but also depressed (a mood or a background feeling) and distrustful (a disposition). For that reason, ‘emotional injustice’ should be reserved for affective injustice with regard to episodic emotions, provided that such categorization is shown to have explanatory value.

⁹ Whitney proposes uptake injustice as the affective counterpart of testimonial injustice. She does not propose a parallel to hermeneutical injustice, but Pismenny et al. (2024, 159) propose ‘emotional inarticulation’ as an affective unjust hermeneutical gap. Gallegos (2022, 195) points at specific forms of affect-related testimonial injustice and affect-related hermeneutical injustice, considering the interconnection and overlap between impairment to belief-formation and the deprivation of emotional aptness. This link has also been highlighted in the debate of epistemic injustice (e.g. Medina 2013); it has even been suggested that the wrong of epistemic injustice is affective in nature (García Álvarez 2021; see also Zembylas 2022).

¹⁰ See Walter and Stephan (2023) for a useful review of the debate of situated affectivity, and Liao and Brinner (2026) for the related discussion of critical 4E cognitive science. The link between affective injustice and situated affectivity is made explicitly, for example, by Archer (2024), Osler et al. (2025), and Slaby (2023).

¹¹ For example, while harms are almost always understood as acts or situations that result in a moral subject being worse-off, wrongs may be understood as (serious and/or systematic) harms, right violations, violations of normative expectations, or instances of relational inequality. For a promising distinction between affective harms and affective wrongs, see Walter and aus dem Bruch (2026). It could also be useful here to borrow insights from similar discussions with regard to epistemic injustice (e.g. Dunne & Kotsonis 2025).

¹² See Helm, 2017; Scheffler 2010; Tiberius 2018.

¹³ The debate on affective injustice has so far been formulated in mostly anthropocentric terms. However, in the same way other theories of justice have evolved to include non-human animals and other entities, there is no reason why these cannot also be incorporated into the debate of affective injustice, particularly given the growing philosophical literature on animal emotions (see e.g. Millar 2024).

¹⁴ See Whitney (2018, 498; 501) on affective injustice and intersectionality.

¹⁵ A related worry is that uptake of disruptive emotions may itself be problematic within some ethical frameworks—for example, African relational moral theory, where harmony is at the centre of morality (Carman 2024).

¹⁶ The discussion of personal relationship goods can also help the lacuna on the conditions for affective justice (see section 6.3). For example, See also Lynch (2020) for a pluralist account of affective equality with regards to care, love, and solidarity.

¹⁷ Other critics within the debate have raised concerns about the plausibility of distributing affective goods (Bell 2023; Stockdale 2023).

¹⁸ Affective justice has also been briefly discussed by Carman (2024) and Zembylas (2022).

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